# A SHIRAZI VISITOR FROM THE DECCAN

When the ruler of the Bijapur Sultanate in the Deccan, Ali Adil Shah I, was murdered in 1580 by ‘two handsome eunuchs who had for a long time excited his perverse attention’, this not only brought to power an extraordinary woman as regent, Chand Bibi, but also provided the necessary impetus for a famous Shirazi intellectual to leave the suddenly uncongenial court of Bijapur for the much more attractive one at Fatehpur Sikri. An enormous sum had been spent by Ali Adil Shah I to lure the scholar Fath Allah Shirazi from Persia to Bijapur where he had rapidly gained a considerable reputation. ‘All the great Muslim scholars, as well as Hindu sages,’ writes historian Ali Anooshahr, ‘would attend scholarly discussions held at his house.’ Now with the death of the Adil Shah, Akbar sent Abdur Rahim and Abu’l Fath Gilani to receive Fath Allah Shirazi and he was made joint wazir of the Mughal Empire along with Raja Todar Mal. The two men together brought about enormous changes in the organization of the revenue and other administrative departments as they brought in Persian as the language of administration at all levels, thus making of Akbar the first Indo-Islamic Padshah of north India to declare Persian as the official language of administration. An eighteenth-century historian recorded this measure in the following way:

> Earlier in India the government accounts were written in Hindi according to the Hindu rule. Raja Todar Mal acquired new regulations from the scribes of Iran and the government offices then were reorganized as they were there in wilayat (Iran).

Now Persian became the language of government at all levels, and was no longer simply an elite courtly language. Since a great deal of the administration was carried out by Hindu communities, these groups learnt Persian and worked alongside the ‘wilayatis’ as clerks, scribes, and secretaries. This was only possible because of the upheavals in the madrasa education system that Akbar had brought about in parallel. This reform was planned and executed by Fath Allah Shirazi and brought about an overhauling of madrasa education at all levels, transforming it from just